Nationalism in India

The big idea

In India, as in many colonies, modern nationalism grew out of the **anti-colonial movement**. Different groups (peasants, tribals, workers, businessmen, students, women) suffered under British rule in different ways. In the 1920s and 1930s, **Mahatma Gandhi** and the **Congress** tried to forge these groups into one movement. The chapter follows the **Non-Cooperation** and **Civil Disobedience** movements and asks: how did people come to feel they belonged to one nation?

The First World War, Khilafat and Non-Cooperation

The war (1914–1918) created a new economic and political situation:

- Huge rise in **defence expenditure**, financed by war loans and increased taxes; customs duties raised and **income tax** introduced.
- **Prices doubled** between 1913 and 1918, causing extreme hardship.
- **Forced recruitment** of soldiers in villages caused widespread anger.
- In 1918–19 and 1920–21 crops failed, and an **influenza epidemic** followed; 12 to 13 million people died of famine and epidemic.

The idea of satyagraha. Gandhi returned to India in **January 1915** from South Africa, where he had fought racist rule with **satyagraha**, which stresses the **power of truth** and the need to search for truth. Without seeking vengeance or being aggressive, a satyagrahi can win the battle through non-violence by appealing to the conscience of the oppressor.

GANDHI'S FIRST SATYAGRAHAS IN INDIA

- **1917 Champaran (Bihar)**: inspired peasants to struggle against the oppressive **plantation (indigo)** system.
- **1917 Kheda (Gujarat)**: supported peasants who could not pay revenue because of crop failure and plague; demanded relaxation of revenue collection.
- **1918 Ahmedabad**: organised a satyagraha among **cotton mill workers**.

The Rowlatt Act (1919) was hurriedly passed through the Imperial Legislative Council despite united opposition of Indian members. It gave the government enormous powers to repress political activities and allowed **detention of political prisoners without trial for two years**. Gandhi launched a nationwide satyagraha, with a hartal on **6 April 1919**.

Jallianwala Bagh (13 April 1919). In **Amritsar**, martial law had been imposed and **General Dyer** took command. On the day of **Baisakhi**, a crowd (many from villages unaware of martial law) gathered in the enclosed ground of Jallianwala Bagh. Dyer blocked the exit points and opened fire, killing hundreds. His object was to "produce a moral effect" of terror. Crowds took to the streets in many north Indian towns; the government responded with brutal repression.

Khilafat. After the Ottoman Turkey's defeat in the war, there were rumours of a harsh peace treaty on the Ottoman emperor, the spiritual head of the Islamic world (the **Khalifa**). A **Khilafat Committee** was formed in Bombay in **March 1919**, led by the brothers **Muhammad Ali and Shaukat Ali**. Gandhi saw this as a chance to bring Hindus and Muslims together in a unified movement.

At the **Calcutta session (September 1920)** Gandhi convinced leaders of the need for non-cooperation in support of Khilafat and swaraj; at the **Nagpur session (December 1920)** the programme was adopted.

WHY NON-COOPERATION?

In his book **Hind Swaraj (1909)**, Gandhi declared that British rule was established in India with the cooperation of Indians, and had survived only

because of this cooperation. If Indians refused to cooperate, British rule would collapse within a year, and swaraj would come.

Stages proposed: surrender of government-awarded titles; boycott of civil services, army, police, courts, legislative councils, schools and foreign goods; then a full civil disobedience campaign if the government used repression.

Differing strands within the Non-Cooperation Movement (from January 1921)

In the towns: the middle class led the way. Students left government schools, headmasters and teachers resigned, lawyers gave up practice. Council elections were boycotted in most provinces except **Madras**, where the **Justice Party** (party of non-Brahmans) contested. Foreign cloth was burnt in bonfires; the **import of foreign cloth halved between 1921 and 1922**, from ₹102 crore to ₹57 crore. The movement slowed because **khadi was more expensive** than mill cloth and **alternative Indian institutions** (schools, courts) were not available quickly enough.

In the countryside:

- **Awadh**: peasants were led by **Baba Ramchandra**, a sanyasi who had earlier been to **Fiji** as an indentured labourer. They protested against talukdars and landlords who demanded high rents and begar (forced labour). **Nai-dhobi bandhs** were organised. By October 1920, the **Oudh Kisan Sabha** was set up headed by **Jawaharlal Nehru**, Baba Ramchandra and a few others.
- **Gudem Hills (Andhra Pradesh)**: tribal peasants, whose forest grazing and collecting rights had been closed off, launched a militant guerrilla struggle led by **Alluri Sitaram Raju**, who claimed special powers yet praised Gandhi. He was captured and executed in 1924.
- **Assam plantations**: under the **Inland Emigration Act of 1859**, plantation workers were not allowed to leave the tea gardens without permission. Hearing of the movement, thousands defied the authorities and headed home, believing Gandhi Raj was coming.

WITHDRAWAL

In **February 1922**, after a peaceful demonstration turned violent at **Chauri Chaura** (Gorakhpur) and a police station was set on fire, Gandhi called off the movement. Some leaders, **C.R. Das and Motilal Nehru**, then formed the **Swaraj Party** to contest council elections and argue for swaraj inside the councils.

Towards Civil Disobedience

Two factors shaped Indian politics in the late 1920s: the **worldwide economic depression** (falling agricultural prices from 1926, collapsing after 1930) and the **Simon Commission**. Set up by the Tory government in Britain, the Statutory Commission under **Sir John Simon** arrived in **1928** to look into the functioning of the constitutional system. It had **not a single Indian member**, so it was greeted with the slogan "**Go back Simon**".

In **October 1929**, Viceroy **Lord Irwin** announced a vague offer of "dominion status" and a Round Table Conference. In **December 1929**, the **Lahore Congress** under **Jawaharlal Nehru** formalised the demand for **Purna Swaraj** (complete independence). **26 January 1930** was declared **Independence Day**.

The Salt March. Salt was consumed by rich and poor alike, so a tax on it was an oppressive face of British rule. On **31 January 1930**, Gandhi sent Irwin a letter with **eleven demands**, the most stirring being abolition of the salt tax. When Irwin did not respond, Gandhi started his march from **Sabarmati** with **78 volunteers**, walking over **240 miles** in **24 days** to the coastal town of **Dandi**, where on **6 April 1930** he ceremonially violated the law by making salt from boiling seawater.

HOW CIVIL DISOBEDIENCE DIFFERED FROM NON-COOPERATION

People were now asked **not only to refuse cooperation** with the British, but also to **break colonial laws**: salt law, forest laws, refusal to pay revenue and chaukidari taxes, and picketing of liquor shops.

When **Abdul Ghaffar Khan** (a devout disciple of Gandhi) was arrested in April 1930 and Gandhi himself a month later, there was violence. Gandhi called off the movement and signed the **Gandhi–Irwin Pact on 5 March 1931**, agreeing to attend the **Second Round Table Conference** in London (December 1931). The negotiations broke down; Gandhi returned disappointed and relaunched the movement, but by **1934** it had lost momentum.

How participants saw the movement

- **Rich peasants** (Patidars of Gujarat, Jats of Uttar Pradesh): hit by falling prices and high revenue; they wanted revenue reduced. They were disappointed when the movement was called off in 1931 without revision of revenue rates.
- **Poor peasants**: wanted unpaid rent to landlords remitted; Congress was unwilling to support no-rent campaigns for fear of upsetting rich peasants and landlords.
- **Business classes**: wanted protection against imports and a rupee–sterling exchange ratio that discouraged imports. **Purshottamdas Thakurdas** and **G.D. Birla** attacked colonial control; they formed the **Indian Industrial and Commercial Congress (1920)** and the **Federation of the Indian Chamber of Commerce and Industries (FICCI, 1927)**. They were worried by the spread of militant activities and the growing influence of socialism.
- **Industrial workers**: barring the Nagpur region, participated only partly; Congress did not include their demands so as not to alienate industrialists.
- **Women**: participated in large numbers in protest marches, salt manufacture and picketing, though Gandhi saw their duty mainly at home.

Limits of the movement. Dalits ("depressed classes") were ignored by Congress for long. **Dr B.R. Ambedkar** organised them into the **Depressed Classes Association (1930)** and clashed with Gandhi at the Second Round Table Conference by demanding **separate electorates** for dalits. When the British accepted this, Gandhi began a fast unto death. The result was the **Poona Pact of September 1932**, which gave depressed classes **reserved seats** in provincial and central legislative councils, but voted by the general electorate. Many

Muslim leaders felt alienated after the decline of Non-Cooperation–Khilafat and growing communal clashes. **Muhammad Ali Jinnah** was willing to give up separate electorates if Muslims were assured reserved seats in the Central Assembly and representation in proportion to population in Muslim-dominated provinces (Bengal and Punjab). At the **All Parties Conference in 1928**, **M.R. Jayakar** of the Hindu Mahasabha strongly opposed compromise.

The sense of collective belonging

Nationalism spreads when people believe they are part of the same nation. This was built through:

- **Images**: the identity of India came to be visually associated with **Bharat Mata**. **Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay** wrote **'Vande Mataram'** in the 1870s as a hymn to the motherland, later included in his novel **Anandamath**. **Abanindranath Tagore** painted Bharat Mata as an ascetic figure, calm, composed, divine and spiritual.
- **Folklore**: nationalists recorded folk tales, songs and legends. **Rabindranath Tagore** collected ballads, nursery rhymes and myths in Bengal; **Natesa Sastri** published *The Folklore of Southern India* in four volumes.
- **Flags**: during the Swadeshi movement in Bengal, a tricolour (**red, green and yellow**) was designed with **eight lotuses** representing eight provinces of British India and a **crescent moon** for Hindus and Muslims. By **1921**, Gandhi designed the Swaraj flag: a tricolour (red, green and white) with a **spinning wheel** in the centre, representing the Gandhian ideal of self-help.
- **Reinterpretation of history**: nationalist writers urged readers to take pride in India's great achievements in the past and struggle to change the miserable conditions under British rule.

COMMON DATE MIX-UPS

Rowlatt satyagraha 6 April 1919; Jallianwala Bagh 13 April 1919; Dandi salt law broken 6 April 1930. Chauri Chaura was February 1922, not 1921. Poona Pact was 1932, not 1931.

BOARD FAVOURITES

"Why did Gandhi withdraw the Non-Cooperation Movement?", "Why was salt chosen as a symbol?", "How did different social groups view Civil Disobedience?" (5 marks), "Why did the Simon Commission face protest?", "How did images and folklore create collective belonging?" Map work: mark **Champaran, Kheda, Ahmedabad, Amritsar, Chauri Chaura, Dandi, Calcutta (1920), Nagpur (1920), Madras (1927), Lahore (1929)** on an outline map of India.

Quick recap

- WWI brought price rise, taxes, forced recruitment; Gandhi used satyagraha at Champaran, Kheda, Ahmedabad.
- Rowlatt Act and Jallianwala Bagh (1919); Khilafat Committee (1919); NCM adopted at Nagpur, Dec 1920.
- NCM withdrawn after Chauri Chaura, Feb 1922; Swaraj Party formed.
- Simon Commission 1928; Lahore Purna Swaraj 1929; Dandi March 1930; Gandhi–Irwin Pact 1931; Poona Pact 1932.
- Bharat Mata, Vande Mataram, folklore and flags built collective belonging.

Practice questions

1. Under the Rowlatt Act of 1919, political prisoners could be

   (a) deported to Fiji (b) detained without trial for two years (c) fined but not jailed (d) tried only by Indian judges

2. Who led the peasant movement in Awadh during Non-Cooperation?

   (a) Baba Ramchandra (b) Alluri Sitaram Raju (c) Sardar Patel (d) Abdul Ghaffar Khan

3. Gandhi called off the Non-Cooperation Movement in 1922 because of

   (a) the Gandhi–Irwin Pact (b) the arrival of the Simon Commission (c) the violent incident at Chauri Chaura (d) the Poona Pact

4. The Simon Commission was opposed mainly because

   (a) it was led by Lord Irwin (b) it wanted to abolish the salt tax (c) it was appointed by the Congress (d) it did not have a single Indian member

5. The Poona Pact of 1932 gave the depressed classes

   (a) separate electorates (b) a separate province (c) reserved seats in legislatures, voted by the general electorate (d) representation in the Viceroy's council only

6. Under the Inland Emigration Act of 1859, plantation workers in Assam

   (a) were given land of their own (b) could vote in council elections (c) were paid a fixed minimum wage (d) could not leave the tea gardens without permission

7. The flag designed during the Swadeshi movement in Bengal had eight lotuses representing

   (a) eight religions (b) eight provinces of British India (c) eight leaders of the Congress (d) eight demands of Gandhi

8. Why did Gandhi choose salt as the symbol to unite the nation in 1930?

9. How did different social groups participate in the Civil Disobedience Movement, and why did each have its own expectations?

Answers: 1. b 2. a 3. c 4. d 5. c 6. d 7. b 8. see notes 9. see notes